

KUSHAGRA WADHWA

says Parameswaran Iyer, executive director of World Bank and former CEO of NITI Aayog. He adds that in this year's Union budget, there is a special focus on expanding the tourism sector by announcing the development of 50 new destinations, setting up unity malls, additional retail for handicrafts, and connecting over 50 wildlife and tourist destinations. Arjun Ram Meghwal, the Union minister of culture, said all three components of India's GDP—consumption, exports and investment—will gain from tourism development. "We should expand our definition of tourism. If a person is going to a temple for *darshan*, that is religious tourism. Or if someone is going to an ashram to learn, that is spiritual tourism. We can also have village tourism, night tourism, Ayush tourism, and so on," says Meghwal.

"Tourism contributes to the GDP—it boosts consumption through domestic travel, investment through the private sector and exports through the sale of handicrafts"

ARJUN RAM MEGHWAL
Union Minister of State for Parliamentary Affairs and Culture

Raj Chengappa, India Today Group editorial director (publishing), also highlighted why tourism is a critical sector not just for India but for the world. "We at INDIA TODAY believe that this sector is critical for the development of the country. We have such magnificent things to showcase and this is the time to create the revolution. The WEF [World Economic Forum] global tourism council white paper notes that tourism contributes almost 10 per cent to the GDP of many countries, including India, and that one out of every 10 jobs in the world is generated by tourism."

Experts agree that innovation is the way forward. Many states have begun investing in adventure, wedding, religious, Buddhist, winter, water and cruise tourism packages, to name a few. Uttarakhand tourism minister Satpal Maharaj stresses, for instance, on diversification: "We have diversified our tourism circuits so that people come to visit different parts of the state and can see how old our culture is." From caravan to spiritual river tourism, the state has put a lot on offer. In Himachal Pradesh, too, authorities are focusing on expanding interest in places beyond Shimla and Manali. "Tourists don't want to go to known destinations. People are keen about homestays and natural spaces, more than hotels in congested towns," says Harshwardhan Chauhan, industries minister, Himachal Pradesh.

The 'dekho apna desh' webinars organised by the Centre have also helped. "We are taking a 360-degree view to develop the tourism sector," says Singh. The tourism ministry is working alongside the ministry of ports, shipping and waterways, the ministry of aviation